

K. PANDIA RAJAN

45, HR ENTREPRENEUR
MD, MA FOI CONSULTANTS
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1992 **Rs 60,000**
TURNOVER IN 2008 **Rs 750 crore**

H. K. RAJASHEKAR



success MANTRA

Karma capitalism.
"Allow nature to
settle. Work with
nature, not against it."

biggest OBSTACLE

When the Babri
Masjid demolition
led to a ban on hiring
of Indians in the Gulf

on their GROWTH

An amazing
70 per cent annual
growth rate for
over 16 years

WORD PERFECT

When K. Pandia Rajan, an engineering student in Coimbatore, participated in a college strike he did not know life would never be the same again. "My tryst with the strike made me interested in the psychology behind human decisions. At XLRI, Jamshedpur, I chose personnel management and industrial relations because of these reasons," says Rajan, now MD, Ma Foi—India's biggest HR company with a French name, meaning 'my word'. Why French? Because his initial clients were from the oil and gas industry, so he used a word which was well understood by them. Born into a family running a match factory in Sivakasi—known for its cracker industry—it was unimaginable to venture into HR. His foray into entrepreneurship began when he witnessed a major fire mishap in the early nineties at the Ravva oil fields in Andhra Pradesh, where an Australian company hired to extinguish the blaze earned a neat \$1 million for bringing in 35 specialists. "Almost all the specialists were Indians. The fact hit me: a nation with a billion people needs organised HR. And with the support of my CA wife Latha, we started Ma Foi Management Consultancy in 1992."

It was not smooth sailing. The Babri Masjid demolition brought a ban on Indian workers in the Gulf and the dotcom bust hit badly. Rajan pledged his wife's jewellery, stabilised the business and then started eyeing the world. "The difficult part was to persuade our 278 shareholders to part with their holdings as the company was like a family," says Latha Pandia Rajan, director, Ma Foi. Today, it prepares an appointment letter every seven minutes, has a database of over 14.07 lakh resumes and provides manpower to 36 countries. It plans to beat the recruitment rate of the government-owned employment exchanges and aims at bridging the divide between the industry's requirements and the skills of the Indian workforce. On the flip-side, Rajan has joined the rising political party DMK. He also supports microfinance, education and health initiatives. Time to give back to his people.

by S. Serthil Kumar